never forget. Our boys are now in positions where they can fight and show what they're worth. They're just itching for a chance to have a real good crack at the Chinks.'

For Army HQ and the army commander to expect that Se-la would hold out for even two weeks was pure wishful thinking, especially since infiltration routes on either flank had not been studied. Se-la certainly would have been a formidable obstacle had it been selected six months previously and if the Chinese had obliged and assaulted only along the road axis.

One of the key reasons the Chinese did not chase the Tawang garrison across the Mago/Tawang Chu immediately was to lull the Indians into believing that they were happy with the capture of Tawang and would not undertake any further offensive action in the Kameng Frontier Division. Already the Indian leadership had demonstrated to the Chinese just how inflexible they could be. So convinced were they that the Chinese were not going to launch an offensive during the coming winter that even the frenetic construction of the Bum-la-Tawang road (clearly visible from Nuranang) did not shake them out of their complacency.

However, despite everything falling into place for the Chinese, General Liu Bocheng's plan was a bold but dangerous gamble. To outflank Se-la and push his troops behind the garrison onto the Se-la–Dirang–Bomdila road meant that the Chinese troops would have to be self-contained, each man at best carrying a week's ration and limited ammunition. Should the Se-la brigade actually dig in and decide to fight an isolated battle, a face-to-face clash would be inevitable. Following 62 Infantry Brigade's lead, should 65 Brigade close ranks and hunker down at Dirang Dzong, then 48 and 67 Brigade could mop up the Chinese systematically. But then battles are not won by taking timid decisions and the Indians until then had given the Chinese no reason to believe that they had the stomach for a fight. Bocheng was fully aware of the capability of the Indian troops; now he simply had to make sure he got into the minds of the Indian commanders. Even the best troops in the world need to be led and until then the HQs of 4 Division, IV Corps, Eastern Command and New Delhi had not been doing a very good job.

On 29 October, orders were issued by the CMAC to the Tibet Military Region that outlined the attack plans for the battle of Se-la, Dirang Dzong and Bomdila. The major guidelines were to cut off Bridge 1 and Bridge 2